My research question is:
How do college students change the way they write depending on who they are communicating with?
I chose this question because it seems genuinely compelling to me. Anecdotally, the journal entries have involved me writing in a pretty snarky way. I think part of this is because I am not certain how closely my professor reads them, which has made me wonder how much the perceived expectations of an audience influence the effort and tone a student puts into their writing. I also noticed in the group project, that some of the writing from my peers seemed to not really be productive, there were some responses that were just questions in the form of an answer. Either way iThis got me thinking about whether students who are primarily motivated to communicate something to their professor write differently from students who are primarily motivated by completing an assignment and receiving a grade. So I wanna look into how college students write for various purposes to various audiences. For example I think an email trying to convince a professor for an absence or extension etc would be notably different from a submission for a writing course due to the change in motive, even though the audience of the writing remains the same the purpose may genuinely influence the tone, length, and even originality. One possible sub-question is whether students are more willing to produce writing when they have a personal or practical reason for doing so, compared with when writing is required for a grade. I could investigate whether students' motivation affects the amount of effort they put into different types of writing. I might develop the nature of the question in a few specific ways, but it is genuinely intriguing to me, and seems like collecting data won't be impossible.

I personally have a lot of disdain towards assignment based writing. I really do like reading research papers and appreciate their format and tone, because they communicate concrete ideas quickly. However, having to communicate in a formal tone as an expectation irritates me pretty badly. It feels like it inhibits me from getting to a point I am trying to make when I have to restructure syntax and exchange words for partial synonyms that make me feel like I am sacrificing clarity in describing what I am thinking. I think formal writing has its place though, and I do think a research paper is the place for it, but I am not convinced that writers should always have to adopt a static and highly formal tone simply to communicate their ideas and opinions effectively.

The reading that most specifically guided this research question for me was Sadie Raghunand's "The Rhetoric of BookTok." Raghunand examines how BookTok influencers use rhetoric within a specific online community and finds that the community has developed its own conventions, including a generally comedic, relatable, and lighthearted tone (Raghunand 25, 34–35). She also discusses how the intended audience and purpose of a piece of writing can affect what is considered appropriate rhetoric. This made me interested in whether college students similarly adapt their writing to fit the expectations of different audiences and situations. In particular, I want to investigate whether those adaptations are primarily motivated by a desire to communicate effectively with an audience or by external expectations such as grades.

Human behavior has always been interesting to me, and this paper discussed informal language. I thought it would be interesting to contrast why various amounts of formality are used and how much of the motivation behind the decisions of this change between audiences is driven by necessity for a grade. Beyond that though all of the readings we have encountered in the course have just been analysing types of writing in similar ways so it's hard to attribute my motivations to a specific few, the rhetoric of booktok did inspire me to do some kind of analysis of tonality though.

This question is relevant to Writing Studies because writing is influenced by more than the information a writer wants to communicate. Writers also have to consider their audience, purpose, and the situation in which their writing will be read. Raghunand's analysis demonstrates how a community can develop particular expectations for communication, which makes me interested in whether similar patterns occur among college students. I want to examine how audience and purpose affect the rhetorical choices students make when they write.

As for how I might collect research data, I plan on interviewing people with survey questions that I can develop statistics for, but I'll also keep conversational notes and see if anything non-prescribed ideas show up and make for compelling questions to ask as I go. The good news is a I know a lot of collage students who are friends and family of mine so finding people to survey should be easy, but I’m gonna try to account for bias by asking outside of my degree program (computer engineering) and those immediately tangential to it (electrical egn, comp sci, etc). As for those "prescribed" questions they should be on these few specific topics:

- The intended audience - who they are writing to and how that affects their approach
- The purpose of the writing - what they are trying to accomplish
- The level of personal motivation - whether they actually care about what they're writing or are primarily trying to complete an obligation
- The expected formality - how formal they believe they are expected to be
- The amount of effort - how much time and thought they put into writing for different audiences and purposes
- The tone and language they use - whether they consciously change their vocabulary, syntax, humor, personality, etc.
- The perceived consequences - whether grades, professional consequences, social judgment, or other incentives affect how they write
- Their willingness to write - whether they are more or less willing to produce writing depending on the situation

Works Cited

Raghunand, Sadie. “The Rhetoric of BookTok.” *Stylus: A Journal of First-Year Writing*, vol. 13, no. 2, Summer 2023, pp. 17–52.